prime minister for the second time in August 2016, heading the 21st government since the 1990 uprising and the end of absolute monarchy.

Nepal's chronic political instability has put the country's two powerful neighbours, India and China, on a direct collision course with each other. Neither India nor China wants an unstable Nepal, but their respective strategic interests could not be more different. India's relationship with Nepal is, of course, much older and more profound than China's and, as in Sikkim and Bhutan, it began with the British East India Company.

Before Prithvi Narayan Shah, the ruler of Gorkha, unified the country in 1768, Nepal was divided into many smaller monarchies. He subdued them, and also managed to avoid the East India Company, which had sent an expeditionary force of 2,400 men into the hills to aid the traditional rulers in the Kathmandu valley. Many of the British soldiers succumbed to malaria before they even reached the valley and had to withdraw. Taking advantage of a religious festival, Prithvi Narayan Shah marched unopposed into Kathmandu, crowned himself king of the entire country, and established the Shah Dynasty, which, at least on paper, was to rule Nepal until 2008.

As the kings of Nepal expanded their territories—they occupied Sikkim in 1788 and sent military expeditions into Tibet in the 1790s—they were forced to confront their more powerful neighbours. The Tibetans appealed for help from the Chinese emperor Qianlong, who sent his army into Tibet in 1792. The Nepalese then turned to the East India Company for assistance, but the British did not want to challenge China, a country with huge trading opportunities. The Chinese drove the Nepalese out of Tibet and came within striking distance of Kathmandu. The Nepalese were forced to sign a humiliating treaty that deprived them of all their trading privileges in Tibet.

Nepal came into conflict with the British again when Kathmandu began to conquer territories south of the mountains. After Nepalese forces attacked a police station in Butawal in the southern plains and killed 18 officers in April 1814, war broke out. It ended two years later with the Treaty of Sagauli[46]: Nepal lost Sikkim and several southern areas that it had conquered; the king in Kathmandu was also forced to accept a British resident in his capital, which made the Nepalese fear for their independence. The British, however, found some of the areas in the south too difficult to govern and therefore turned them over to Nepal, which